

NAME

gen-passphrase – Generate random passphrases

SYNOPSIS

gen-passphrase [options] initials|word-count min-len max-len

Options:

-help -help1 -help2	Show short medium long usage message
-man	Show long usage message (invokes pager)
-n	Don't print a newline after the passphrase (This interacts poorly with "-verbose")
-[no]suffix	Allow/disallow words ending in s, ed, ing (enabled by default)
-verbose	Show statistics about the strength of the passphrase
-dictionary file	Use specified word list Default is /usr/share/dict/words or \$PASSPHRASE_DICT
-dev-random	Use /dev/random rather than /dev/urandom (slow)
-debugging	Produce debugging output (developer option)

DESCRIPTION

gen-passphrase generates random passphrases.

It is part of the **random-passwords** package, available at

<<https://github.com/Keith-S-Thompson/random-passwords>>

More documentation is available there.

gen-passphrase was partly inspired by this XKCD cartoon: <<http://xkcd.com/936/>>, which suggests using long passphrases consisting of randomly selected English words. The example in the cartoon was "correct horse battery staple" (of course you shouldn't use *that* specific passphrase).

The passphrase consists of a sequence of words randomly selected from the specified word list file. Only words consisting entirely of ASCII lower-case letters are considered. The three command-line arguments (following any options) are:

1. **Either** a string of ASCII lowercase letters **or** a decimal integer specifying the number of words;
2. The minimum length of each word; and
3. The maximum length of each word.

OPTIONS

All options may be abbreviated uniquely. **-help** may be abbreviated as **-h**.

-help

Show short usage message

-help1

Show medium usage message

-help2

Show long usage message

-man

Show long usage message using **perldoc**, invokes pager

-n Don't print a newline after the passphrase.

(This interacts poorly with the **-verbose** option.)

-[no]suffix

-suffix, the default, allows words ending in s, ed, and ing (which are typically forms of other words).

-nosuffix excludes such words. This typically reduces the number of available words by about half. If you use this option, use **-verbose** to see the effects, and consider using more and/or longer words.

-verbose

Show statistics about the strength of the passphrase

-dictionary *file*

Use specified word list

Default is /usr/share/dict/words or \$PASSPHRASE_DICT

-dev-random

Use /dev/random rather than /dev/urandom

This can be much slower and is probably unnecessary.

-debugging

Produce debugging output (developer option)

SEE ALSO

gen-passphrase, also part of the **random-passwords** package.

<<https://github.com/Keith-S-Thompson/random-passwords>>.

AUTHOR

Keith Thompson <Keith.S.Thompson@gmail.com>

LICENSE AND COPYRIGHT

random-passphrase is released under GPL version 2 or later.